

in your overall bill. The Energy Information Administration (EIA.gov) found that 42% of home energy costs go to heating and cooling, so it's essential to get this part under control!

You can adjust the temperature manually, or buy a programmable thermostat to do all the adjusting for you. Be careful that you don't micromanage too much, though. Constantly changing the temperature wastes more energy than it saves. Here are the two areas I would focus on if you want to see significant savings:

- **In the Winter:** Keep your house at 68° while you're awake and at home, and lower while you're asleep or away.
- **In the Summer:** If you have air conditioning, keep your house at 78° while you're awake and at home, and higher while you're away. You may want to keep the temperature at 78° or lower while you're asleep, as trying to go to bed in a very hot house makes for an uncomfortable situation!

Note: Those who live in hotter climates without much change in season (like Florida) will need to adjust their temperature accordingly.

During the fall and winter months, you may also want to turn off the heat completely, and try using space heaters in areas of the home where you spend the most time. We do this quite often in the winter so our air conditioning system doesn't have to constantly shift between heating and cooling, wasting more energy. Don't be afraid to shut off other parts of your home either. Rooms that don't get much use should be closed off so they don't take extra heat to warm them up, or air to cool them down.

2. CHECK YOUR WINDOWS AND DOORS FOR LEAKS

In the past, we have both rented and owned 100-year-old houses in NY that made it quite difficult to be energy efficient. Nothing makes your furnace or